

School Committee Meeting Notes, December 21, 2020

Mayor called meeting to order - 6:04 PM

Roll call - 7-0 / Salute the Flag

Mayor - Approval of Minutes - December 7th Meeting

Member Ruseau - Question on notes - when a positive comes back on Abbott/Binax test, does that get counted in the city and state reports?

Ms. Wray - needs to be confirmed with a PCR test, so eventually it would be reported - both responses have to be reported to the state

Motion to approve by Member Ruseau, seconded by Member McLaughlin

Roll Call 7-0 - minutes approved

Mayor - Approval of Bills

Motion to approve by Member Van der Kloot, seconded by Member Kreatz

Roll Call - 7-0 - Bill approved

Member Van der Kloot - Report of Secretary - continuing signing bills - earlier this week - lots of hand sanitizer and covid bills

Mayor - Rules Committee Notes Approval

Member Ruseau - to recommend new policy

Motion to Approve by Member McLaughlin, seconded by Member Graham

Roll Call - 7-0 - Notes approved

Member Ruseau - new policy recommendation, voted unanimously - original policy in packet as well as new policy are in your packets - observance list is new - static date observances and in addition and variable dates - and we identified no school days and there are 2 other categories -

excused absences and blocked - dates when people will be going to school/work, important enough, so major exams/school events should be taking place on the blocked days

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December 21, 2020 - School Calendar Cover Memo

Good evening,

As requested by this body, the Rules, Policy, and Equity Subcommittee met to consider our process of school year calendar creation in recognition of the opportunity to improve upon this important aspect of planning for so many within our community.

The subcommittee members, Member Graham, Member McLaughlin, and myself, in collaboration with the Superintendent and several members of her staff, and importantly with assistance from members of our community representing many faiths, have updated our existing policy and expanded upon it to include an Observance List.

I am proud of the work of this group - and the effort to get us here was significant.

I also want to acknowledge that like all good policy work, it is never done. I would not be surprised if there is an error here or there, and I am certain there are some omissions, specifically there are no Sikh or Native Peoples observances. I am hopeful you will join me in approving this policy and working towards refinement in the coming years.

I urge anyone with knowledge of omissions and or corrections to please reach out to any member of the School Committee so that they may submit a motion to adjust the Observance List and move us closer to the goal of respecting all those that call Medford home.

Respectfully submitted, Paul Ruseau, Chair, Rules, Policy, and Equity Subcommittee & Vice Chair, Medford School Committee

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - I appreciate the work on this calendar to help make the school calendar more inclusive and include all religions. Thank you

Member Graham motion to approve the revised policy from the Rules Committee, seconded by Member McLaughlin

Roll Call 7-0 - Policy is approved

Mayor - Approval of Curriculum Subcommittee Notes of December 10th

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Member Van der Kloot - December 10th Curriculum Subcommittee - Math presentation - Member Graham reminded us to develop a catalog of all instructional areas, so we wouldn't implement new curriculum across the board - Envisions curriculum - due to Covid, piloting new programs, was put on hold - Illustrative Math - Middle Schools - a step and a much rigorous

Member McLaughlin - any special education supplements? Do we know if there are supplements for math, and for EL?

Member Van der Kloot - I can't address that specifically - we will absolutely follow up on that

Member McLaughlin - I respectfully ask that those questions regarding special education supplements are addressed

Member Graham - as we create the catalog we want to include special education and EL supplements as well as

Motion to approve by Member Graham, seconded by Member McLaughlin

Roll Call - 7-0 - Paper passes

Mayor - Committee of the Whole, December 16th Meeting Notes - the new MHS Vision Committee - set out a plan and advertise for members in the new year

Motion to approve by Member McLaughlin, seconded by Member Van der Kloot

Roll Call - 7-0 - meeting notes approved

Mayor - Boy Scouts 416 welcome!

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - so happy to have you this evening

Mayor - Thank you for all of your community participation

Community Participation - Brian Buck, President of Medford Educational Foundation

Brian Buck - TY to students, staff and teachers at MPS - and to Ann & James Kussoth

New officers/ updated mission statement / Fall 2020 microgrants

Brian Buck - President

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Chris D'Aventa - VP

David Sayres - Director of Grants

Clerk - Gail Airsain

Founding member - Member Van der Kloot

Who we are: MEF supports the MPS through grants that fund innovative teaching and professional development - social emotional learning, professional development etc

Received 17 applications for grants up to \$200 - digital form

Proposals included: innovative software to engage during remote learning, Purchasing books and exercise equipment & Training in mindfulness & whole child initiatives

David Sayres - thank you to school committee for welcoming us - there was other specific software for EL and math - personal note, I have 2 kids in the system - thank you for all of your hard work - doing a fabulous job making this work for our kids

Brian Buck - website - www.medfordedfund.org

Email - medfordedfund@gmail.com

Facebook - Medford Educational Foundation

Our goal is to do another round of funding in the Spring - maybe building or system wide grants - let teachers know about us! We are here for resources for innovative teaching ideas

Member Van der Kloot - terrific leadership with Brian and David - Diane Caldwell will be joining our group - need people to help with fundraising - we appreciate the teachers who apply for the grants - Pear Deck - district will supply - I'd like to thank Molly Laden, Chad Fallon, Bernadette Ricciardelli for their expertise - this is good news

Mayor - Member Van der Kloot is a founding member - 5 years ago it was established? - we appreciate the presentation

Mayor - public participation

Member Ruseau - Yes

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Maureen Royane - According to the last available MCAS results, only 35% of 3rd grade students are meeting or exceeding in English Language Arts at the Columbus Elementary School. With the exception of the Brooks, the other schools' scores are not much better. Students should be taught to read in school with evidenced based reading instruction. Private experienced Orton-Gillingham tutors charge between \$100-\$230 per hour. Diagnostic testing is between \$3,000-\$7,500 and it should be done frequently. This is not affordable for many families. Literacy should not be reserved for students that have families with resources. Literacy is a right. I am asking you to make literacy a priority for Medford Public School Students. I am requesting that the superintendent have a literacy outcome goal on her evaluation. Thank you, Maureen Ronayne, Winter Street

Meghan McLyman - submitted same language - outside tutoring at my own expense for her 2nd grader, school isn't educating her in the way she needs - Hello, I know this email is being sent after the school committee meeting tonight, but I wanted to express my support of Maureen Ronayne's statement copied below. As a parent to a 2nd grader with a learning disability, I am quite disappointed with the poor support my child has received from the Columbus School. I have been forced to resort to outside tutoring at my own expense. The challenges of COVID have put new financial stress on my family and I fear I can no longer afford this critical tutoring. She deserves every opportunity to learn to read. The school is not educating her in the ways she needs. I fear she will fall further behind. Thank you, Meghan McLyman

Mayor - Report of the Superintendent

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - I would first like to welcome the Boy Scouts again, as they work on their Community Merit Badge and the MHS Orchestra for their video performance, under the direction of teacher, Ms. Baptist - What an excellent job from our orchestra! Please be aware that each student participated by video in their own home and it took Ms. Baptist over 30 hours to put this 6 minute clip together!

Ms. Baptist - So kind of you all and thank you for watching - last minute editing due to parental consent forms - brand new for me and the students - I haven't met the students in person yet as I'm new - this is such a huge time for music teachers, usually putting on so many holiday shows - the students will have this - it was 100 times harder to do than putting on a concert - happy holidays - thank you

Member McLaughlin - thank you to you and the students for the show - the ensemble piece was excellent - I know I'm missing the live performances as I'm sure we all are.

Member Van der Kloot - I wanted to thank the students and teacher for bringing the concert to us - I certainly miss the live concerts - I was at MHS today and looked at the empty auditorium -

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speaking to a friend from the Gay Men's Chorus - they did a video as well, a load of work involved - thank you so much

Member Kreatz - Thank you for a beautiful performance - this was amazing - Happy Holidays

Mayor - Yes, great job! Thank you!

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - offered sincere thanks to MPS staff for responding so well to weather-related challenges. Reminded everyone about the holiday break. Returning to remote instruction for all on January 4, 2021 - We will resume in person instruction, January 14th. Cohorts A, C and all MPS staff will be covid tested the week of January 12th, details to follow. As of now, we plan to include grades 9, 10 & 11 to return to in school learning on the 14th.

As mentioned our work has been guided by safety, consistency and equity. I want to address how we have met those expectations. We upgraded our HVAC systems, socially distanced our classrooms, provided hand sanitizer throughout our buildings and required that all students and staff wear masks. These safety measures allowed us to welcome our students & teachers back, but we did so gradually, following the health metrics. As for equity, this is an extremely important part of our goals. With assistance from grants and the CARES monies, we were able to purchase enough chromebooks and hotspots so all students had access. However, during this pandemic, we also all witnessed the tragic death of George Floyd, which spurred peaceful protests and rioting. Despite pledges of reform, incidents similar to what happened to Mr. Floyd continues and this is quite shocking. The Medford Public Schools are committed to racial equity and to that end we established the Racial Equity Task Force, made up of students, staff, teachers, parents and administrators. They have met and their goals are to improve our culture and climate throughout our district. Additionally, a few of our task force members are also serving on Middlesex District Attorney Marian Ryan's Anti Racial/Anti Bias Task Force, which she established in early October. People of color need to feel welcomed, considered and cared for in our district. This is difficult and uncomfortable work, but it is work that needs to be done. For change to happen, we all must be committed to it. In the new year, I will discuss more in depth about the Racial Equity Task Force, but I wanted to give you all a brief overview tonight.

\$550 in Donations for the holiday were received by the MHS/MVTHS PTO. The Medford

Family Network donations have been remarkable - toys from floor to ceiling - so moving, made me so proud to be from Medford - It made one realize just how committed Marie Cassidy is to our families. It is a huge undertaking for her to match up the toys with the families

Congratulated Patrick Gordon on his Overall Excellence Award for Community Media in the Northeast Region

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We met today, on the Winter Solstice. Mentioned Jingle Bells was written here in 1850, and that Wreaths Across America laid at Arlington National Cemetery and other national cemeteries across our country.

Lastly extended holiday greetings to all for Christmas and Kwanzaa

Mayor - Thank you Dr. Edouard-Vincent - Now we will hear from Ms. Wray and Ms. O'Connor regarding Medford's covid update

Ms. O'Connor - Community update - more important than ever to heed guidance of the experts, following the spike in cases/hospitalizations after Thanksgiving, sobering - keep our families safe - Mass.gov/holidays - only celebrate with the person or persons in your immediate households - the last state report on December 17th for Medford - 635 cases in past few weeks - since December 12th - an additional 24 cases - don't gather and don't travel - if Thanksgiving is a lesson, we hope people learned from it

Ms. Wray - December - increase in positive cases after Thanksgiving - scattered across district, contact tracings - staff cases doubled from November to December - either community or family transmission - Brooks on remote - 7 staff members tested positive over a 12 day period - we considered it might be an in school transmission - made cautious decision to put Brooks on remote - please follow Gov Baker's wish to not gather - if you feel sick, go to a Stop the Spread and get tested - wishing you a happy, healthy and safe holiday

Mr. Murphy - Covid testing program with Tufts / Armstrong & Broad Institute - we are so grateful and hopeful that it will continue throughout the school year - instill confidence, eliminate spread and minimize instruction disruption - staff testing - Sept 24th and student Nov 30th - non invasive testing - staff- 18 positive results - reached agreement with teacher union for mandatory testing - and will address with other bargaining units - 2900 PCR tests for students - 15 positive test attributed to MPS testing - elementary test are taking about 4-5 minutes and secondary students self swab during lunch - MPS is working with the city and partner to finalize funding sources so that testing can continue for the foreseeable future - Reentry and baseline testing on Jan 12th and Jan 15th - MPS will transition to Pool Testing on Jan 19th - robust communication to convey to staff and families the protocols around pool testing - a lot more information to follow in the coming weeks - no testing the remote week - Jan 4th - all staff are expected to abide

by public health guidance for gathering and travel during the holiday recess, if not, they must test prior to coming back into the buildings - CDC guidance has changed - was 14 days but can be shortened to 10 days, if person tests negative on day 8 - we will maintain the more conservative approach - we will stick with the 10 days, which poses an operational challenge

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Member Ruseau - Email comment - Laticia Rocha - Brooks school - circumstances to go full remote? Public should be made aware of with cases rising in

Mr. Murphy - it was an operational challenge - suspected in school transmission

Ms. Rocha - 2nd week that community transmission rate transfers to the school

Ms. Wray - We have built in many layers of protection for our students/staff - wear masks, frequent hand washing and 6 ft distancing - testing of staff twice a week and follow the CDC recommendations - contact tracing to minimize school transmissions

Mr. Murphy - 2900 student's tested - 15 positives - a testament to our enforcement of the safety protocols - when individuals test positive, they are removed from the school community - and we are vigilant

Colin Bailey - MHS student representative - I'm in the remote - Cohort D - very comfortable with the protocols

Member Ruseau - Ms. Rocha - all students coming back in January - not true, if already remote - remote is not a priority clearly - can Ms. Wray clarify possible in school transmission?

Member McLaughlin - I want to thank Toni and Maryann - standouts in their fields and it's been a lot for them! We had office hours recently and spoke to families in the remote cohort - they would like to feel more welcome and feel more a part of the school - maybe we can create support groups at each elementary, middle & high school level to connect families, maybe a facebook group - they feel very isolated - On another note, my senior went back last week and he was so grateful to be back in school - students felt that Superintendent cares about them

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - I'm open to a support group for remote families - I see us as one community - my sister and nieces are part of the remote cohort - I'm definitely willing to work on that - seeing more bodies at the high school - they are so happy to be back and grateful to be back on campus - this is their last hurrah - I appreciate the feedback - I'll never please everyone, but I will make an intentional reach out to our remote families

Member McLaughlin - Mea and I held office hours and we will see if we can share their contact

information

Mayor - MVTHS Robotics Donation - motion to table, by Member McLaughlin, seconded by Member Kreatz

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Roll Call - 7-0 - donation tabled

Mayor - Italian Donation

Dr. Ricciardelli - Award received by Italian Ministry - last year, our partner group CASIT, ended unexpectedly, due to no funding - they had funded it past 20 years - we applied for a direct grant and Vilma helped as it had to be done in Italian - informed this fall - \$27 Euros - \$32,000 - Medford received the highest award in the U.S. - Elementary 900 students - Middle school and high school are very strong - we told the consulate about the elementary program no longer being held - 2020-2021 - will be utilized for our AP program - Thank you - Italian Ministry and Ms. Federica Sereni, the Consulate General and her staff

Motion to approve by Member McLaughlin, seconded by Member Graham

Member Ruseau - any stipulations? It's a lot of money, but no strings attached?

Dr. Ricciardelli - The money will be used for AP testing, and to defray the cost of AP Italian teacher - reporting is slightly different due to Italian government rules, not American rules.

Roll Call - 7-0 - Paper passes

Mayor - motion to take MVTHS paper off table - by Member McLaughlin, seconded by Member Van der Kloot

Roll Call - 7-0

Principal Fallon - donation from Sam Christy - non profit he was a part of, dissolved and he donated over \$4,000 to MVTHS

Motion to approve by Member McLaughlin, seconded by Member Kreatz

Roll Call - 7-0 - donation acception

Member Graham - very generous of him Can we please send thank you to Mr. Christy?

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - yes of course

Mayor - Old business? Hearing and seeing none. Communications? Hearing and seeing none
New business? Hearing and seeing none

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Mayor - Condolences to the families of Mr. Nick Tomaszczuk and Ms. Annemarie McNamara.

Mayor - Negotiations? None

Member McLaughlin - record for shortest school committee meeting!

Mayor - Happy Holidays everyone!

Meeting adjourned - 7:50 PM